AN ALPHA KINGS ROMANCE



THE ALPHA KING'S CHRISTMAS PROMISE

A Fated Mates Wolf Shifter Romance

ALORA C. KANE



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Midnight Crown Stories

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Chapter One

Alpha King Jarrod Cantrell found the last occupied cottage by following the smell of baking bread. A woman inside sang about good cheer. He had spent the morning emptying farms ahead of the storm. Good cheer had been in short supply.

He left two warriors with the horses and pushed inside with his beta, Rourke. A petite woman stood on a ladder beneath the rafters, brown wool skirts tucked clear of her boots, chestnut curls escaping their pins. She took a ribbon from her mouth and pointed at the door.

"Shut that, please. I've only just got the room warm."

Rourke glanced at him, eyebrows raised. No one ordered their king to tend doors.

Jarrod closed it without comment. "Gather what you need. We're taking you to shelter."

"Are you?" She paused on a lower rung, green eyes considering him. "I have a roof, a full woodpile, and plenty of bread and food. What sort of shelter did you have in mind?"

"Stone walls. The northern slope is unstable. We've brought everyone else down to the shelters. You can return when the storms are over and we've made it safe."

She looked around the room, at the quilt folded beside the hearth and the half-finished garland above it. "I've only just unpacked."

Her disappointment troubled him more than it should have. She was human, without a trace of wolf in her scent. “You live here? Alone?”

“Now I do. It was my grandmother's cottage. She died in the spring.” She descended the remaining rungs and held out one end of the garland. He took it. Up close, the bread and cloves gave way to the clean sweetness of her skin. His restless wolf settled, and Jarrod tightened his hold on the ribbon. Human or not, she smelled remarkably good.

“Noelle Winters,” she said, as though they had met under ordinary circumstances. “And you are?”

“Jarrod. We need to leave.”

“No, I don't believe we do.” She untangled the ribbon. “I've stocked up for bad weather. The principal's daughter may have taken over my schoolroom, but no one is turning me out of my home as well. I've only just made it look like Christmas.”

“This slope could bury you. You cannot risk your life over a few…” He gestured around the room. “Shiny trinkets.”

She lifted her chin. “They are my Christmas decorations, and I won't forget about them. Off you go. I'm sure someone else would be delighted to be rescued.”

The cottage was scarcely large enough for the three of them. Jarrod had to turn sideways to avoid the drying herbs beside the door, and Rourke's shoulder brushed a stocking pinned to a shelf. Two cups stood on the scrubbed table, though only one had been used. Beside them lay a child's crooked drawing of a woman with enormous green eyes.

Noelle noticed him looking. “A farewell present. I was assured it was an excellent likeness.”

“The eyes are right.”

She glanced up, surprised, and he regretted nothing about saying it. Then wind struck the shutters hard enough to rattle their

catch. Jarrod looked toward the small window above the table. The trees on the northern slope were almost lost behind the snow.

"Rourke, have the men check the lower track. If the stream has risen, we take the ridge."

His beta put his head outside and relayed the order. Noelle watched the exchange with more attention than she had given the warning about shelter. Jarrod draped his end of the garland over a chair, then removed his gloves and laid them beside her carpetbag.

"How much warning would I have?" she asked. "If the slope came down?"

"Not enough to reach the door."

Her fingers stopped on the ribbon. He let her look at him, let her see that there would be no comforting lie simply because she wanted one. Her chin remained lifted, but her gaze moved toward the drawing and the cups.

"This is the first place I've had that no one can take away from me."

Jarrod sensed it cost her to admit that to strangers. He lowered his voice. "Then don't let it be the last place you ever see. We leave before the track closes. Tell me what would make it easier."

Rourke looked from her to Jarrod. "I could put her over my shoulder."

"You will do no such thing," Noelle and Jarrod said together. She looked at Jarrod with brief, startled approval.

He lifted the ribbon from the chair and handed it back before his wolf could enjoy that any further. "If the argument is about decorating, bring your ribbons and trinkets."

"Where?"

"To my house. You can finish there." He held her gaze.

"To your house? Not a crowded shelter? And I can decorate?" She looked up at him. He had given villages new wells and watched their elders receive the news with less gratitude and pleasure.

“Well, that settles that, then.” She put the garland into Rourke's hands, adding ribbon and a wrapped loaf. Noelle thanked him and tucked dried orange slices on top. She packed a carpetbag, then paused beside a wooden star above the hearth. Her fingers rested on it before she turned away.

“Do you need that too?” Jarrod asked.

“I'd have to take down the fastening. Grams carved it. It will be here when I come back.” She pulled on her cloak, covering a moonstone pendant.

Before they left, Jarrod checked the latch on the back door and banked the hearth. Nothing she had done was careless. Wood stacked dry, water drawn, food laid in. She had prepared for winter, just not for a mountain sliding into her front door.

“You've managed well here,” he said.

She lifted the folded quilt from beside the hearth and pressed it flat against her chest. “You sounded rather doubtful.”

“Of the hillside. Not of your housekeeping.” He held out his hand for the quilt. “You won't have to prove yourself useful to earn a warm room.”

She looked at him before giving it over. He wondered how often someone had made her feel that she did. Her next smile was smaller than the first, and he found himself wanting to know what would make it come easily.

At the door she paused to pull the stocking from its nail. A paper label was stitched to the cuff in childish letters. MISS WINTERS. Jarrod waited while she tucked it safely inside the quilt. He passed the bundle to Rourke, retrieved his gloves, and pulled them on before taking her hand to guide her over the icy threshold.

Outside, a warrior took her bag while Rourke secured the parcels. Noelle offered Jarrod's horse her palm.

“I've only been in carts,” she admitted. “If you were hoping I'd leap aboard, you've come to the wrong schoolteacher.”

Jarrod handed his reins to Rourke and stepped beside her. “You'll ride with me. Put your foot here.”

She followed his instructions, then glanced over her shoulder. “You won't let me fall?”

“No.” He placed his hands at her waist. “I won't.” He helped her up and settled her at the front of the saddle.

Chapter Two

A cart had sides. A sensible seat. Somewhere to put one's hands that did not require negotiations with a strange man's thighs. Noelle discovered the deficiencies of horseback travel as Jarrod swung up behind her and took the reins from Rourke, enclosing her between his arms.

"Sit back," he said.

She moved perhaps an inch. His chest was broad and warm through his coat. She felt it every time he breathed, which seemed excessively often now that she was paying attention. He drew his cloak around them, enclosing her in the scent of clean cedar. Every step swayed her against him. Sitting stiffly made her bounce. Relaxing settled her more firmly against him. Winter air was no longer her chief concern.

She searched for somewhere respectable to put her hands. The front of the saddle looked promising until the horse began down a slope and she clutched it hard enough to hurt her fingers. Jarrod noticed at once.

"Hold my arm."

"I'm quite secure."

"You're trying to climb inside the saddle." Keeping the reins in one hand, he brought his other forearm across her, close enough for her to take it without reaching. "Here."

His voice left little room for discussion. It ought to have annoyed her. Instead, Noelle curled her fingers around his sleeve and

felt her shoulders loosen. He knew the road, the horse, and precisely how much room she needed to breathe. She could stop managing everything for a few minutes. The relief of that was almost as disconcerting as his proximity.

"Better?" he asked.

She nodded, then remembered he could not see her properly. "Yes. Thank you."

He adjusted his hold as the horse stepped over a fallen branch. Her hand slid nearer his wrist, where a little warmth escaped between glove and sleeve. She was suddenly conscious of having never held a man's arm for so long. There had been dances at the school harvest supper, a farmer's son who smelled of ale, a shy clerk who had spent an entire evening discussing his mother's joints. None of them had made her forget the next word in a perfectly ordinary sentence.

This man was hardly trying. That was the most provoking part.

"Your house," she began. "Does it have a proper hearth?"

"Several."

"And windows?"

"Certainly."

"Of course it has windows. I meant deep sills. For candles." She shifted her skirts and brushed his leg. His hand steadied her waist, and she lost her train of thought. "I... I mean, candles in sills look very welcoming from outside."

"Candles."

"Yes. And greenery around the door. My grandmother said a house should look as though the people inside hope someone will knock."

"A door has a perfectly adequate purpose without all these fripperies," Jarrod noted.

"Oh, Grams would have had words about your entrance." Noelle glanced at his scuffed glove on the reins. "It sounds dreadfully unwelcoming."

“Would she?”

“Quite a number.”

Rourke drew alongside before she could explain further.

“You'll be among wolves, Miss Winters. It would be wise to keep a little out of the way.” Rourke glanced at Jarrod. “Perhaps you could explain.”

“No need. I know what you are. Grams claimed there were wolves in our family. It must have passed me by.” Noelle glanced up at Jarrod. “I would dearly love to see a shift, though. Yes, I know. You don't show yourselves to humans.”

Jarrod's hand lingered at her waist. “You're not frightened of us.”

“I was frightened of the snow coming through my roof. You seemed the more reasonable prospect.” She smiled.

She was explaining how Grams had ended up with a cottage deep in wolf territory when the horse's hoof slipped on a buried stone. The jolt threw Noelle hard back against Jarrod. His arm closed securely around her. Her skirts rode higher over her boots. His hips pressed against her, solid and unmistakably male, and the remainder of her explanation vanished.

“Easy.” He steadied the horse, then bent close. “Are you hurt?”

“No.” Jarrod had not loosened his hold, and she was very much aware of that too.

“You've gone quiet.”

“I am considering the merits of carts.”

She attempted to sit forward. The next step settled her back against him. For a moment he was quiet as well.

Jarrod's warm breath ghosted over her ear. “I was beginning to wonder what it would take.”

“Hmm?”

“To render you speechless.”

Noelle turned her head and found his mouth rather close, its sternness softened by amusement. Snow had caught in his short

dark hair. He was handsome, she realized with sudden irritation. She ought to have looked properly before agreeing to sit here.

"Perhaps you should watch the road," she said, and faced forward again.

"An excellent suggestion." His voice had roughened slightly. It did nothing to improve her composure.

She could feel him smiling. She would have liked to turn and verify it, but that would bring her face close to his again, and she was not at all certain what she might look at first.

"Do you rescue many women this way?" she asked.

"Most are pleased to be rescued."

"That wasn't my question."

His arm tightened briefly as the track narrowed. "Not exactly this way."

She liked the answer more than she should have. Snow hissed against the cloak stretched over their knees. Beneath it she was warm, enclosed in the shelter of a man who seemed to notice each uncomfortable shift before she could hide it. When he lifted his hand from her waist to draw the wool higher beneath her chin, his glove brushed her cheek.

"You'll wear a hole in your lip," he said.

She stopped biting it. "You cannot possibly see that."

"I can see enough."

Noelle looked down at her fingers as she settled them around his arm again. "Then kindly look at the road instead."

He gave a low laugh that she felt against her back. It stayed with her long after he had fallen quiet, a private pleasure beneath the sounds of hooves and harness. She wondered how stern he looked when no one was arguing with him. She wondered whether anyone at his house ever made him laugh.

Noelle let the horse's movement carry her. Jarrod shifted the cloak to cover her hands. Even her moonstone had grown warm.

She assured him she was comfortable and leaned back into his sheltering arm.

Hours passed, but somehow she did not mind them. Eventually, the trees thinned, revealing towers and an enormous gate beneath a silver wolf banner. Guards straightened on the battlements.

"Welcome home, Majesty," one called down.

Noelle turned slowly in the saddle. "This is not a *house*."

"I did say it has several hearths."

"You might have mentioned the battlements." She looked at Rourke, who had suddenly developed a great interest in his parcel. "All of you might have mentioned them."

None of the riders looked at her or answered.

"He could at least wear a crown to warn a person," she muttered under her breath. Jarrod's hand steadied her as she turned back, and she suspected he had heard every word.

They rode through the gate into Cantrell Keep's courtyard. Jarrod dismounted beside the mounting steps and reached for her while a groom took the reins. Noelle put her hands on his shoulders and let him lift her down. Once she stood securely, he offered his arm.

A captain hurried down the steps as they crossed the courtyard. "The east granary roof is taking weight, Majesty. We can keep men up there clearing it."

"Move the grain into the lower store. No one goes onto that roof." Jarrod glanced toward the ice hanging from the eaves. "Close the passage beneath it. Use the kitchen entrance."

"We'll need six more men."

"Take them from the gate rotation. Rourke will arrange relief."

The captain bowed and was gone. Noelle had been watching Jarrod's mouth, remembering its nearness on the horse. Now she watched the courtyard change around his decision. Men turned toward the stores. A guard stretched a rope across the threatened

passage. The people around him were safer because he had looked, understood, and acted.

He glanced down at her watching face. “What is it?”

“I was revising my first impression.”

“Of my house?”

“Of you.”

His gaze lingered on her face. “Take your time.”

For some reason, she suddenly felt as breathless as she had on the horse, with him behind her.

He led her up the steps and into the castle. The great hall was warmed by fires and very little else. Bare stone stretched above long tables. A single silver bowl stood beneath the high windows. A woman in dark blue silk approached, her gaze passing over Noelle's plain cloak and muddy hem.

“Alpha.” The woman inclined her head to Jarrod, then looked at Noelle's hand on his arm. She deliberately sniffed the air. “Shouldn't this woman be taken to a *human* shelter? Are you certain bringing her here is wise?”

“Lady Myla, Miss Noelle Winters,” Jarrod said.

Noelle lowered her hand under Myla’s cool stare.

“She is here at my invitation,” Jarrod said, his voice carrying without rising. “See that she is welcomed accordingly.” He turned to the steward waiting beside the stairs. “A room overlooking the south garden. Have a fire lit before she goes up.”

Noelle looked at him. She tucked her cold fingers into her palm. He seemed to notice every discomfort she tried to overlook.

“And have her things brought up,” he added, passing the parcel Rourke had brought in to the steward.

Behind Myla, silver-bearded Councilor Venn looked at Noelle. “Majesty, the Yule rite is approaching. Bringing a woman here now will raise questions about your choice of mate. The law requires a Luna of wolf blood, and you know how rumors spread.”

“Then I suggest you stop discussing my marriage in front of someone who has just lost the use of her home.” Jarrod offered Noelle his arm again. “Would you like to see those hearths?”

She placed her hand on his sleeve. “Very much.”

At the foot of the stairs, a servant stopped Myla with a question about beds for some of the newcomers sheltering at the castle. The lady turned away from Noelle and answered without consulting the ledger under her arm.

“The Dales need the small room above the kitchens. Amelia's boy must be near warmth. Move the two unmarried shepherds to the west dormitory, and bring another mattress from the linen room.”

“That leaves the washerwoman and her daughters, my lady.”

Myla glanced toward the crowded hall. “My maid can sleep in my dressing room. Give them hers.”

The servant thanked her and hurried away. Noelle looked after Myla with a reluctant adjustment of her own opinion. The woman might dislike her, but she knew who needed shelter. It made the coldness directed at Noelle feel more deliberate, not less.

* * *

The next morning, Noelle watched guards cross the courtyard roped together. Snow rattled her bedroom window. Thinking of Pinehollow's wooden walls, she went downstairs to thank Jarrod for bringing her somewhere safe. He was inspecting the battlements, the steward told her. Returning to the stairs, she passed the scribes' open door.

Three men worked at a broad table beside the windows. Their dispatches waited for the roads to clear. Noelle asked to use the paper scraps beside their ledgers. Soon they were folding stars with her, and the eldest was demonstrating an improvement when Myla stopped in the doorway.

“What is going on?” Myla looked from the scribes to the paper ornaments. “We do not decorate for the Yule rites. These are for a human festival.”

“Holiday,” Noelle corrected. “Jarrod said I could decorate the castle.”

“It’s Alpha King Jarrod. You are entirely too familiar. His Majesty would never have authorized this.”

“He did,” Rourke said behind her. He squeezed past with a basket of greenery. “I was there.”

Myla left with her skirts snapping against the doorframe. Noelle turned to the eldest scribe. “I don't want to interfere with your rites. What do they involve?”

“Thanksgiving to the Moon Goddess for her bounty. Prayer and the first offering from our stores.” He set down his scissors. “I'll fetch some books from the library.”

While he fetched them, Noelle brought a tray of spiced tea from the kitchens. “Thank you for your hard work,” she said, pouring. The men warmed their fingers around their cups while she read about packs sharing feasts and winter gifts after the offering. She marked a passage with ribbon.

Carrying the decorations and spare paper back upstairs, she heard children reciting beyond an open door. Noelle stopped at the crowded schoolroom. A weary woman explained fractions at the blackboard while two boys argued over a slate. She gratefully accepted Noelle's offer to help. The farm children had nearly doubled her class.

Noelle took a group to the long table beside the windows and showed them how to divide paper into equal pieces. She was cutting the first star when Myla appeared in the doorway again and beckoned her over.

“Only wolves should teach wolves,” Myla said quietly, her lips drawing back from teeth too sharp for a human mouth. “Four words, Miss Winters. ‘Human flesh. Wolf teeth.’”

Noelle kept her voice pleasant. “Here are four for you. ‘King's protection. Christmas cheer.’ You might try remembering both.”

Behind her, the teacher gave a startled guffaw and covered it with a cough. Noelle returned to the children. “Now, halves remain halves whether you shift or not. Who can show me a quarter?”

Later, when the children had gone to their midday meal, Noelle found Myla outside the linen room checking blankets against her ledger. She stopped beside the open door.

“The Dales were comfortable this morning. Amelia asked me to thank whoever found them that room.”

Myla's pen paused. “It was the appropriate place for them.”

“Still. It was kind of you.”

The lady looked at her then, as though kindness were an imprecise word for something that had required considerable calculation. A maid came to take the counted blankets. Myla waited until she had gone before closing the ledger.

“I've spent six winters helping prepare shelters just like these. I know which roofs leak and which families cannot be housed together. My father expected me to learn the work.”

“It seems useful work to know.”

“For a Luna, essential.” Myla smoothed the cuff of her sleeve. “People notice garlands. They rarely notice the blankets were ready before they needed them.”

Noelle heard the hurt beneath the polished voice and wished, briefly, they had met somewhere without a king between them.

“I noticed,” she said.

Myla's expression tightened. “You will be leaving when the roads clear, Miss Winters. Those of us who remain must consider more than whether the hall looks welcoming.”

Noelle stood aside to let her pass. She could understand wanting one's work to matter. She understood it too well to mistake the warning for anything gentler.

Chapter Three

On the third day, Jarrod crossed the great hall with a dispatch. Families from the shelters sat near the hearths while servants laid the tables for the midday meal. Pine and spice hung in the warm air, thick enough that he tasted it. His home had never been quite so… inviting.

Noelle stood beneath the arch beside the stairs, and Rourke followed with a ribbon basket. She caught Jarrod's sleeve before he reached the council room. Her fingers closed on the leather, and his wolf, which had been pacing since dawn, went still.

She nodded toward a bough on the table. "Just above the arch. You're exactly the height I need."

"I have men who can do that."

"Yes, but you're here."

He tucked the dispatch into his belt and pulled off his gloves, slower than he meant to.

She handed him the bough. Needles pricked his palm as he lifted it to the hook above the arch under her watchful eyes.

"A little higher on the left. Your left. Yes, there."

Once the bough was resting on its hook, she stepped in to tie the trailing ribbon around the pillar beside him. Her shoulder brushed his chest. Heat followed the contact, sharp and uninvited, and he held still because moving would have meant putting his hands on her. A curl had slipped loose against her cheek. He watched it, and found himself wondering whether his hands were

clean enough to tuck it back. Whether she would let him. Whether she would lean into it.

She finished the knot and smiled up at him. Close enough that he could have counted her lashes. Close enough that her breath warmed the hollow of his throat.

"You see? Quite painless."

"Speak for yourself," Rourke muttered, passing with a basket. "I did not survive three wars to spend my winter fetching ribbon."

"Then it's fortunate you've survived long enough to learn something new," Noelle told him.

She plucked two pine needles from Jarrod's collar. Her knuckles grazed the skin above his pulse. The touch went through him like a struck match, down his spine, into his hands, into the place behind his ribs where the wolf had been waiting. He looked at her mouth before he could stop himself. Soft. Slightly parted. She had been humming earlier, and he could still hear it.

Her hand paused at his glance. Color rose in her cheeks. She did not step back.

"There," she said, and dropped the needles onto the table as if they had burned her. "Now you can go back to looking like a King."

"I never stop." His voice came out lower than he intended. "But if it gives you an excuse to touch me, I can be patient."

He watched her cheeks color deeper. A child called from the hearth. Noelle went, a little too quickly, and Jarrod finally remembered the dispatch and headed to the council room, still feeling the ghost of her knuckles at his throat.

When he emerged an hour later, the meal was being served. The scent of pine mingled with cloves and vanilla from the Christmas bread on the tables. People grumbled about a human teaching their children while reaching for the food she'd introduced. Near the hearth, a mother knelt beside a bench with a bowl. Her boy had crawled under the table and refused to come out.

Noelle was sitting on the rug beside the open end of the table. Jarrod crouched beside her, his shoulders outside the low space. The boy peered at his boots, then up at his face.

“He wants his own bed,” Noelle explained. She passed Jarrod one end of a ribbon, then offered the other to the boy. “Would you show Jarrod how to tie it? He has had very little practice.”

The boy crawled closer. Noelle showed him where to fold the ribbon, and Jarrod held still while small fingers pulled a crooked bow tight around his wrist. Then the child crawled out beside his mother. Noelle helped him onto the bench, and his mother passed him the bowl. Firelight caught Noelle's eyes in a pale gleam, but when she stood they were green again.

Returning from the serving trays, Rourke eyed the bow. “Shall I add ribbons to the uniform?”

“Yours first,” Jarrod said, leaving his own in place. He waited until the boy and his mother rejoined their family, then turned to Noelle, who had crouched to collect the loose ribbons from the rug.

“You miss teaching,” Jarrod said.

“Dreadfully.” She folded a ribbon end. “My pupils made me presents last Christmas. One boy gave me a stone because it was shaped like my head. I still have it. I've written to them. An unemployed spinster must find some useful occupation. Otherwise we become peculiar and start keeping seventeen woodland creatures.”

“A spinster,” Jarrod repeated, getting to his feet. “How old are you?”

“Twenty-three. A terrible age. All the girls I went to school with are married, and several have begun worrying about me.”

He studied her until her smile became uncertain. “What?” she asked.

“I was trying to imagine a line of badgers outside your door, waiting to be told to wipe their feet.”

“They would be very well behaved.”

“I'm less persuaded by the rest of it.”

“People stop asking after a while. They find other things for you to do. Mind the children, help with the supper. You become useful.” She gathered the scraps too quickly. “And I like being useful. I didn't mean to complain.”

“What had you planned to do at Pinehollow?” Jarrod asked.

“Tutor the children on the farms around Pinehollow. Grams earned her living that way before she married.”

“In wolf territory.”

“Yes, and wolf children need arithmetic too. They don’t seem to care as much if one is human.” She glanced toward Myla, who sat at the table beside an empty chair, glaring at her. She put the last ribbon in her basket and stood. “I hadn't expected to miss a whole roomful of children quite so much.”

Jarrod took the basket before she could carry it back to the stairs. “Sit down.”

“There's still the stair rail.”

“Sit down and eat with me.” He pulled out a chair at a small table beside the hearth.

She looked at the chair, then at him. “You needn't keep me company merely because I'm a guest.”

“Noelle, I have spent the last three days inventing reasons to walk through this hall. Sit down before I have to think of another.”

Her lips parted. She took the chair, and Jarrod set the basket beside it. He asked a servant to fetch their meals and tea before sitting opposite her. When the tray arrived, he poured two cups. Across the hall, Venn and two elders discussed the dispatch. Here, the fire was close and Noelle's knees nearly touched his. She smiled, and he wanted to move closer.

“Does Lady Myla know you wander about looking for schoolteachers?”

He put down the pot. “The Council favors the match. I have never agreed to it.”

“And what do you favor?”

He looked at the ribbon still tied around his wrist. “Until recently, finishing my work without interruption.”

He saw her pleasure before she lowered her eyes. As he served the bread, she glanced toward the elders at the other end of the hall. “Is it only the teaching they object to? Lady Myla thinks being human disqualifies me from almost everything.”

Jarrod set down his knife. “My mother was killed by human hunters. The Council considers that sufficient reason never to trust one near me.”

“And you?”

Jarrod looked at Noelle, who had made room for frightened children beneath his own tables. “I am beginning to think they have been advising me badly.”

She did not offer an easy reassurance. She rested her hand near his, giving him time to accept it. He laid his fingers over hers. For a while they ate with her hand in his, awkwardly and with no particular wish to make it easier.

* * *

Later that afternoon, Jarrod found her in the small west parlor, standing on a footstool beside the window. The room overlooked the sheltered garden and was seldom used in winter. A basket of ribbon sat on the sofa, and a single evergreen branch refused to stay hooked above the curtain rail.

Noelle looked down as he shut the door against the draft. “You have excellent timing.”

“I’m beginning to recognize that tone.”

“Hold this for me.”

He took the branch. The needles were cold. She was not. Heat rose off her in the close air of the parlor, pine and winter roses and the faint sweetness of whatever she had been tasting in the kitchens.

He reached past her and fastened the branch. His chest nearly brushed her back. He heard her breath catch, small and sharp, and the sound went through him like a brand laid to bare skin. She turned on the stool to face him, and he set both hands at her waist. She was warm through the wool. Narrow. Real. His thumbs found the dip above her hips and stayed there a moment longer than the task required.

"Down."

"I can step off a stool."

"Then do."

She put her hands on his shoulders as he steadied her. He took her weight as she stepped down, drawing her slowly past him until her skirts whispered against his legs. Once her feet touched the carpet, his hands remained where they were. He had intended to let go. She was looking up at him, her fingers resting against the wool of his coat, and intention seemed a very poor reason to stop touching her.

He could feel her breathing under his palms. He could feel the wolf leaning forward inside his skin, hungry and certain, even when it should not be.

"Thank you," she said more quietly.

"You're welcome."

He brushed a loose curl away from her mouth. The pad of his thumb grazed the corner of her lip. Her eyes followed his hand, and beneath the hand still resting at her waist he felt her breathing change, a little unsteady. All morning he had watched people bring her tasks, children bring her questions, Rourke bring her greenery. For once he wanted her attention entirely to himself. No court. No ribbon. No excuse but this.

“Noelle.”

She lifted her chin. He gave her time to turn away. She did not. He bent and kissed her.

Her mouth was softer than he had let himself imagine. For one unsettling instant she held very still, and he drew back enough to see her face. Her lashes were dark against her cheeks. Color had risen high along her throat.

“Was that unwelcome?”

“No.” The answer came quickly, followed by a blush. “Merely unexpected.”

“Then I’ll warn you about the next one.” His thumb moved against her cheek, slow, tracing the heat there. “It’s coming now.”

She laughed against his mouth, and he drew her closer, one hand spreading at the small of her back, gathering her in until there was no honest space left between them. The second kiss held none of the caution of the first. He felt her relax into him, then felt her begin to answer, her mouth opening under his, and the effort of keeping his wolf quiet became considerable. Heat licked down his body. Her sweet scent filled his head. Her hands slid from his shoulders to his collar, fingers curling in the cloth as if she meant to keep him there, and he let her. He learned the softness of her mouth and the little pause she took before kissing him again, a hitch of breath that nearly undid him.

When he raised his head, her eyes were still closed. Her lips were faintly wet. The sight made him want to forget the rest of the castle, the storm, and every law that said he could not have this.

“Jarrod,” she said, opening them at last. His name in her voice sounded like something he had been waiting years to hear.

“Yes?”

“I believe the branch is secure.”

“I am not holding you up for the sake of the branch.”

Her smile appeared slowly. He kissed its corner, then her cheek, then the place just beneath, unable to resist the simple pleasure of

making her lean toward him. She made a small sound that was not quite a laugh. She had brought noise, ribbons, and a great many inconvenient desires into his ordered house. He wanted her to bring more. He wanted her mouth again. He wanted her warmth under his hands until the fire burned down and no one in the Keep remembered to come looking.

The latch lifted. Jarrod turned, keeping Noelle beside him as Venn stopped in the doorway.

"Majesty. The grain allocations." The councilor's gaze moved from Jarrod's hand at Noelle's waist to her flushed face.

"I'll join you shortly."

"This cannot wait."

"It will wait outside."

Venn's mouth tightened, but he withdrew and shut the door. Jarrod looked down at Noelle. She had straightened her collar, and the pleasure in her expression had become guarded.

"I should finish the schoolroom stars," she said.

"Look at me." He waited until she did. "You have nothing to be ashamed of."

"I'm not ashamed. I am wondering whether you'll still want to kiss me when he has finished speaking to you."

He brought her hand to his mouth. "That is one thing Venn will not be deciding."

She studied him, then picked up her basket. Jarrod opened the door for her and waited until her footsteps had faded before facing the councilor.

Venn held his papers against his chest. "Human women are not suitable companions for the Alpha King. You know the prohibition."

"I know the law."

"Then remember why it exists. Your mother trusted humans."

Jarrod went very still. Along the corridor, a servant saw his expression and quietly turned back the way she had come.

“My mother was killed by hunters,” he said. “Miss Winters is a schoolteacher. You will not use one woman's death to make me cold to another.”

“And if the attachment grows? You cannot offer her the place she will expect. Are you prepared to make her your mistress?”

His wolf rose at the word. Jarrod held it, held his temper with it, and took the papers from Venn's hand.

“You will address her with respect. You will leave her out of conversations about my obligations. Bring those to me.” He looked down at the figures. “Now explain why you have reduced the eastern shelters' share.”

Venn began his explanation. Jarrod listened, corrected the allocation, and sent the councilor to the steward. Only when he was alone did he look toward the stair Noelle had taken. Wanting her had become easy. Finding a future he could ask her to accept required more of him than a kiss in a quiet room.

He would not begin by letting her believe that kiss had been a mistake. Before supper, he went upstairs to find her.

Chapter Four

On Christmas Eve afternoon, Noelle read by the fire in the sitting room adjoining her bedroom. Outside, the snowfall had dwindled to a few drifting flakes. For the past two evenings, ever since their kiss in the west parlor, Jarrod had called for her before supper. She was listening for his footsteps. Today his knock came early. Setting the book on the small table between the hearth chairs, she went to the door.

He held her grandmother's wooden star in a clean handkerchief. Noelle stepped back to let him in, and he closed the door behind him.

"The slope came down at Pinehollow," he told her. "The roof and north wall are wrecked. This was found beside the hearth. We'll see what can be saved when the pass clears."

Noelle took the star. She pictured her grandmother's chair and the window where she'd planned to put a candle. She might have been sitting there when the snow struck. Jarrod held her shoulder while she ran her thumb over its uneven points.

A little soot marked the handkerchief, and one point of the wood had been chipped. Noelle rubbed it with her thumb. Her grandmother had never quite managed to make the points equal, though she had maintained that a star was entitled to a personality.

"She made me hold it while she painted it," Noelle said. "I complained about getting gold on my fingers."

Jarrod's hand settled over hers, stilling the frantic rubbing. “There is gold left.”

She nodded. Such a little thing to save from a house, and yet he had understood why it mattered. She could almost hear Grams telling her to stop fussing and put the kettle on for the man who had brought it back.

“You remembered,” she said.

“You looked back at it.”

She stepped into him and wrapped her arms around his waist. He held her without speaking, his coat cool against her cheek. “I didn't know anyone was watching,” she said.

He bent his head over her curls. “I was.”

When she could let him go, Noelle cut a ribbon, and Jarrod fastened the star above the hearth. She returned to her chair and opened the book on her lap. He drew the other hearth chair alongside hers before sitting down.

“I've been reading about your Yule rites. Some customs are so like our Christmas. Other packs share a feast after the offering and give winter gifts.” She showed him a passage marked with ribbon. “This one hangs evergreen branches to honor the life that survives the cold.”

Jarrod leaned closer to read. “Venn would insist ours is the only proper way.”

“I wouldn't change the prayer or offering. I'd like the children to understand what you're giving thanks for, then have their songs and presents. We could share the Christmas food afterward.”

Jarrod looked at the orange slices drying by the fire. “My grandmother came from another pack. Perhaps that explains something. My mother put an orange in a stocking for me at Yule. I never understood why.”

“She must have learned it from her mother. Did you like finding it?”

“I hated oranges.” His mouth moved faintly. “But she brought them in herself. They were difficult to get in winter. I ate it while she watched, and Rourke had the sweets waiting afterward.”

Noelle pictured the boy with sticky fingers, determined not to disappoint her. “You must have loved her very much.” She covered his hand. He turned his palm beneath hers, and they sat quietly until the log settled.

“I had the kitchens send for more,” he said. “Oranges. I thought you'd want them.”

“Jarrod.” She looked down at their joined hands, her throat too tight to say anything else.

“I'll speak to Mother Agatha,” Jarrod said. “She's due back from the northern shelters tomorrow. The pack will listen to her about the rites.” He glanced at the book. “Change isn't easily welcomed from a human guest. I'll show her these accounts. But I, for one, do like it. What you’ve done.” His gaze traveled over the decorations that had changed a cold castle into a home.

Noelle nodded. He had listened. That alone would have been enough to undo her, after days of being treated as an inconvenience in a borrowed hall. His thumb moved over her knuckles, slow, a small circling warmth she felt all the way up her arm.

She remembered the west parlor. The stool. His hands at her waist. The first kiss, careful, and the second that had not been careful at all. The way her mouth had opened under his before she had decided to let it. The hitch of her own breath. She had caught herself remembering the taste of him hours afterward, in the middle of garlands and children's questions. She wanted it again with a hunger that embarrassed her. She wanted his mouth, and the heat of his palm at her back, and that low voice saying her name as if it belonged to him.

When he looked at her mouth and leaned closer, she forgot supper entirely. She forgot the book and Mother Agatha and the rites. She only lifted her face and waited, her pulse loud in her

throat, her fingers tightening on his as if she might keep him there if the castle tried to take him back.

A knock interrupted them. At Jarrod's call, the door opened and Rourke appeared. The western bridge needed closing before the next front. Jarrod shut his eyes, then stood, still holding her hand.

“I'll come back for you before supper,” he said. He touched her cheek before letting go.

Half an hour later, as Noelle sorted her lesson plans, Myla knocked at her open sitting-room door. “You know Widow's Hollow? A message has come. Amelia Dale and her son went back for medicine, but they’ve been gone too long. He's likely too weak to walk up again.”

Noelle put down the papers. “Has someone told Jarrod?”

“Alpha King Jarrod,” Myla corrected. “His Majesty has the bridge to contend with. We have no one to spare to take supplies. They mostly need blankets and food while they wait for transport. The next snow isn't expected until tonight.”

“It's barely half a mile by the lower path,” Noelle said. They’d passed the Dale farm on the way to the Keep, and Rourke had pointed it out. “I'll take the blankets and supplies. A sick child shouldn't have to wait.” She checked the window. A few flakes drifted past the glass, no worse than when Jarrod had left.

With blankets from the linen room and food wrapped inside them, Noelle stopped at the steward's desk downstairs. There she wrote down her destination and Myla's report. “If Jarrod asks for me, give him this,” she said, handing him the note. The steward was already turning to a servant with another question as she gathered her bundle and left through the gate. Before she reached the homestead, wind was driving snow between the trees, and she could barely see its shutters.

She reached the porch breathless. The door and windows were not only shuttered but nailed fast from outside. Noelle knocked,

called, then tried the handle. “Hello. Amelia?” No one answered. She gripped the blankets, watching the path disappear beneath the snow.

Chapter Five

Jarrod returned from the bridge eager to take Noelle down to supper and perhaps steal the kiss Rourke had interrupted. Instead, the steward met him at the foot of the stairs with a folded note.

At the steward's desk, Jarrod checked the shelter ledger. Amelia Dale and her son were listed in Myla's own hand, with no departure recorded. He passed Noelle's note to Rourke. "Check their room. Now."

Rourke went straight to the rooms above the kitchens. Moments later, he returned with confirmation that the Dales had never left.

"Confine Lady Myla to her rooms until I return," Jarrod told Rourke. "Find out exactly what she told Noelle. If the ridge closes, look for us at Greenwood." Jarrod turned for the stables.

* * *

Jarrod found Noelle on the Dale farmhouse porch, clutching her bundle of blankets. Her open relief nearly made him miss his footing as he dismounted. He looped the reins over the porch rail, took the bundle from her, and set it on the bench beside the door before catching her by the shoulders and rubbing her arms.

"Are you hurt?"

"Only cold. There isn't anyone here, Jarrod. I think they must have left or been picked up already."

"Amelia and her boy are safe at the Keep. They never came back here."

She looked back at the shuttered door. “She said there was no one to bring them supplies.” Her fingers tightened on his coat.

“Myla knew they were safe. She sent you here deliberately, and I will find out why.” He drew her into his coat, lowering his voice against her hair. “But first I'm getting you warm. I thought I might be too late.”

“I should have asked you. Or found someone who could ride. I’m sorry I added to things you have to worry about.”

The wind had washed most of her tracks away. At the last turn he had found one small bootprint filling with snow and ridden harder, unable to keep from imagining her beyond the next drift. Now she was within reach and still trying to explain why she had come.

“Listen to me,” he said, holding her gaze. “You were told a child needed help. The fault belongs to the woman who lied. You and I will discuss walking out into weather like this when you can feel your hands.”

“I can feel them.”

He took one between his palms. Her fingers scarcely bent. Noelle looked down at them and stopped arguing. He tucked them against his chest while he pulled the dry lining of his coat around her.

“For now, you stay close and do as I say.”

She nodded. The trust in that small movement reached him through the anger and fear. He wanted to carry her all the way home. Instead, he made himself look at the road and choose the shelter he could reach before the storm took the choice from him.

She gripped his lapel, and he covered her hand before helping her onto the horse. He secured the wet bundle behind the saddle, untied the reins, and mounted behind her. She settled against him, cold wool and the frantic beat of her heart, and his wolf surged so hard he had to set his jaw. The ridge back to the Keep was hidden

by snow. “My hunting lodge, Greenwood, is below these trees,” he told her, turning down the wooded track.

The timber lodge stood beneath the hill. He helped Noelle down, carried in the blankets, and left the horse tethered beneath the lean-to roof while he brought her inside. Jarrod lit the lantern hanging by the door. Its light revealed a stone hearth, two chairs, and a table beside the pantry shelves. A curtain screened the sleeping alcove. He got a fire burning, pulled a chair close, and spread the sodden blankets nearby to dry. Even soaked, her scent rose with the steam. Pine. Warm skin. The same sweetness that had undone him in the west parlor.

“Your cloak,” he said, undoing the clasp. His fingers worked at her throat, stiff with cold. The metal was icy. The hollow beneath it was not. He felt her swallow against his knuckles and made himself finish the task. “Boots too. There are dry shirts and stockings in the chest beside the bed. Change behind the curtain while I see to the horse.”

She looked around as he fetched a dry blanket. “You have another house.”

“This one is a house.”

“And not a sprig of holly anywhere. You really cannot be left unsupervised.”

He laughed and went to stable the horse in the attached lean-to. Returning, he hung his coat beside her wet things. She was sitting, curled under his blanket, the cuffs of his wool shirt rolled back from her hands. The shirt was too large. It had slipped off one shoulder. Firelight found the line of her collarbone, the damp curl at her temple, the bare skin of her throat where her cloak clasp had been. He heated water and brought her a cup of tea because looking too long felt like a claim he had not yet earned the right to make.

Noelle caught his hand. “Yours are frozen. Sit down.” She pointed to the second chair. “You can't scold me into getting warm while you drip all over the floor.”

Jarrod passed her the tea. She took a grateful swallow and set it on the table while he sat. Keeping the blanket around her shoulders, she fetched a cloth from the open chest and stood before him, rubbing his damp hair with brisk, careful hands. No one had done that since he was a boy. Her body was close enough that the blanket brushed his knees. Each pass of the cloth sent heat down the back of his neck. Jarrod lowered his head, then found he had closed his eyes. When she finished, her fingers rested at his nape, light as a question, and his wolf went utterly still beneath them.

He looked up. She was close enough to kiss, and this time there was no summons waiting at the door. He touched her waist beneath the blanket and felt her move toward him, the shirt warm from her skin, nothing between his palm and the shape of her but wool. Her mouth was warm, her hand tightening against his neck as he drew her nearer. He had meant to stop after one kiss. Then she kissed him back, opening to him with a small sound that went through him like a brand, and stopping became considerably less appealing.

He gathered her in, one hand spreading at the small of her back, the other sliding up into her hair. She tasted of tea and cold air and the storm she had walked into for strangers who had never been there. The wolf wanted more. Teeth at her throat. His mark on the place his fingers had found when he undid her cloak. He kept it leashed and kissed her deeper instead, learning again that little pause she took before answering him, the way her breath hitched when his thumb moved against her hip through the wool.

The cloth slipped to the floor. Noelle laughed softly when he finally lifted his head. “You appear to have warmed up.” He kept his arms around her for another moment before trusting himself to answer. Her mouth was faintly wet. Her eyes had gone dark. He

wanted the curtain, the bed, the whole night, and he wanted it badly enough that he made himself loosen his hold. This was forbidden. Not wrong, just not allowed.

"I was about to say the same," he managed.

Eventually she suggested supper. He changed his damp shirt for a dry linen one behind the curtain, then found bread and cheese while she fetched apple preserves from the pantry. He set out their plates and sat at the table as the storm roared beyond the shutters. She found a spoon for the preserves and took the chair beside him.

The preserves had been put up in summer. Noelle held the jar beneath her nose and smiled before passing it to him.

"Cinnamon. Someone thought you deserved better than cold meat."

"The housekeeper. She mistrusts my ability to feed myself."

"A sound judgment. You were about to eat that bread without anything on it."

"I was looking at you."

Her spoon stopped halfway to the jar. Jarrod took it gently from her hand, served the preserves, and returned it. He was enjoying how little effort it took to interrupt her instructions now that she knew he meant what he said.

"You cannot use that excuse for everything," she told him.

"I've used it once. I intend to see how well it works."

She shook her head, but her knee stayed against his beneath the little table. He could hear the horse shifting in the lean-to and the slow scrape of branches against the roof. The house needed wood, the animal needed hay, and Noelle needed another cup of tea. For the first time in years, the list of decisions he had to make and work he had to accomplish was negligible.

She spread preserves on a second piece of bread and put it on his plate without asking. Jarrod had been served at practically every meal of his adult life. This felt different. She had noticed he

was hungry while he was still noticing how the fire warmed her cheek.

"Do you come here often?" she asked.

"When I can."

"To hunt?"

"Sometimes. Sometimes to finish a thought without someone entering the room."

Noelle looked toward the curtain and the solitary bed beyond it. "It must be quiet."

"It was."

She glanced at him. He smiled before she could apologize for filling the quiet, and felt her knee press a little more firmly against his.

"I wanted one good Christmas," she said. "That sounds so foolish now."

"It doesn't." He broke off a piece of the bread she had put on his plate.

She looked toward the fire. "I visited the cottage whenever I could find a ride from town. After Grams died, I stayed in the school lodgings. I couldn't face the cottage without her. When I lost my position, I lost the lodging as well."

Jarrod set down the bread. She had kept herself so occupied that he had mistaken her warmth for happiness. "Is that why you were hanging everything when we came?"

"I thought reopening the cottage and doing our usual things might make it feel like Christmas. I could tutor the farm children. Even alone, it would still be a life." She gave an embarrassed laugh. "I didn't mean to take over your entire castle."

"I've been considering having the halls searched every time I couldn't find you." He took her hand. "Will you stay? After the storms have passed?"

Noelle looked down. "I wouldn't want to displace the teacher, but she could use help, even after the farm children return home."

Her fingers shifted against his. “I know what it is to lose a classroom to someone with better connections. I would want her to welcome the help.”

“I want you.” He waited until she looked at him. “At supper. Beside the fire. Here with me when neither of us has anything useful to do.” He drew her fingers to his mouth. “People have needed me all my life. I hadn't realized how much I could need someone to stay until you came.”

Her lips parted, but no answer came. Jarrod held her hand. “I believe you're my mate, Noelle. Do you know what that means?”

The fire crackled. She did not pull away, but he saw the care with which she considered it. “Is that why you've been so kind to me?” Noelle asked.

“You told me to shut your door before I had even scented you. I've been trying to understand you ever since.” He brushed his thumb over her wrist. “My wolf knew before I did. I wanted you while I was still arguing with him.”

Her mouth curved, then grew serious again. “And the law?”

“Still stands. I won't pretend otherwise.” He kept her hand in his. “But I will not take Myla as my chosen mate. I won't put you in some quiet house and call when the Council isn't watching. Whatever it takes to settle this, I'll face it with you.”

She studied him for long enough that he felt every second. Then she leaned forward and kissed the scar across his knuckles. “I liked you when I thought you had a house with deep windowsills. I should tell you that before you start offering me anything else.”

“I won't let you decide tonight because you're grateful I found you,” he said. “Nor because the cottage is gone. You have a place at the castle whatever answer you give me.”

Noelle's expression sharpened. “Do you imagine I would agree to marry a man for the sake of a roof?”

“I imagine you've had a frightening day.”

She considered that, then set down her cup. “Yes. And when I heard the horse, I wasn't relieved that someone had come. I was relieved it was you.” She put her hand over his. “I should like a less frightening day with you as well.”

“Several.”

“We might begin with one.”

“I'm a man accustomed to making plans, Noelle. You'll have to allow for it.”

Her fingers settled between his. Outside, the shutters shook. He had never wanted a tomorrow quite so plainly.

He touched her cheek. She leaned into his palm, then turned her face to kiss it. They sat listening to the fire, discussing nothing more urgent than how much honey she wanted in her tea. Later, he fed the horse and brought in enough wood to keep the fire through the night.

Chapter Six

When Noelle could no longer hide her yawns, Jarrod turned down the bedcovers in the alcove and left the curtain drawn aside. She sat on the bed's edge, the blanket around her shoulders, watching him fetch spare quilts from the chest and spread them on the hearth rug. He folded his coat for a pillow. His feet would be almost under the table.

"You cannot possibly be comfortable there," she said.

"I'll manage."

"There's room in the bed. We're sensible adults."

He looked at her until she drew the blanket higher beneath her chin. "I'm trying very hard to be one," he said.

She felt the heat burn her cheeks, but held his gaze. "I know."

He brought the lantern to the shelf beside the bed, then waited while she slipped beneath the covers before lying down beside her with a careful space between them. The storm pressed at the shutters. She could hear him breathing, too even to be sleep. When she shifted her foot, the mattress dipped toward him, and the heat of his body reached her across that careful inch of linen. She lay still, wanting, and not quite daring. The minutes passed. She tried counting backward, a remedy she had recommended to sleepless pupils, and lost her place whenever he moved.

Her fingers found his. He closed his hand around them at once. She let out a small, relieved breath.

"You aren't sleeping either."

“No.” He turned toward her. Firelight caught on his mouth. “Are you cold?”

She shook her head. “That isn't the problem.”

He lifted his free hand to her face. She moved to meet him. The kiss began gently enough that she felt herself smile against it. She freed her hand from his, closed it in his shirt, and brought him back to her. His mouth opened over hers. Heat spilled down her throat, into her breasts, low into her belly. She drew breath against him only because she had to.

“Noelle.” He rested his forehead against hers. “If you want to sleep, tell me now.”

“I've been trying to sleep for an hour.” She slid her hand to his nape, where she had touched him beside the fire, and felt him shudder under her fingers. “It hasn't helped.”

He kissed her again, deeper, and she answered with a sound she had not meant to make. She settled against him. The wool of his shirt rasped her bare legs. He was hard against her hip, unmistakable even through the linen, and the knowledge of it made her pulse stumble. When he paused, searching her face, she touched his mouth with her thumb.

“I want you, Jarrod. Shall I say it again?”

“Yes.” He kissed the inside of her wrist, slow enough that she felt every point of heat. “Though I warn you, I may ask more than once.”

He caught her hand before she could draw him closer and kissed her fingers, one unhurried press across the knuckles. She watched him, her usual answers gone somewhere she could not reach. The satisfaction in his smile told her he liked that. She found, to her own surprise, that she liked him seeing it.

“You needn't look so pleased with yourself,” she murmured.

“I have every reason.”

She touched the corner of his mouth. “There you are. I knew you were smiling.”

He turned his face into her palm. Then he drew her close and kissed her with none of the restraint he had kept at the castle, and she opened to him at once. No court. No ribbon. No one about to lift a latch. Only his mouth, and the weight of his hand at her back, gathering her in until her breasts pressed to his chest and she could feel the hammer of his heart.

When she caught her breath, he rested his forehead against hers. "Tell me if I hurry you."

"You have been maddeningly slow for days."

"I was trying to behave."

"I noticed. I began to take it personally."

He lifted his head. "Never that."

The teasing went out of her. Her hands slipped beneath the loosened collar of his shirt and found the heat of his shoulders, the old ridges of scars, muscle held too tightly. He bent to kiss her again, and she met him without hesitation.

One of her remaining hairpins caught his sleeve. She made an exasperated sound and reached up. He stopped her hand.

"Let me."

He worked the pin free, then found the others, setting them on the small shelf beside the bed. Her curls loosened under his fingers. He smoothed them back with a care that made her throat tight. She was unused to someone taking such care over her, and unused, still more, to wanting to lean into it.

"Better?" he asked.

"Much. Though I shall never find them in the morning."

"I know where they are."

"Of course you do."

The smile she gave him then was unguarded. He kissed it. She mapped his face with her hands, the scar near his jaw, the hair at his nape, and stopped trying to anticipate him. When her fingers tugged his shirt, he sat up and pulled it over his head, and fire-

light ran over him, all scar and shadow and the controlled power she had been pretending not to notice.

She sat up too. His wool shirt, the one she had borrowed, came off in his hands. Cool air found her skin. Then his gaze did, dark and intense, and she had to fight the urge to cover herself. He looked as if he were committing her to memory. When he finally reached for her, his palms were warm on her waist, then higher, until he filled his hands with her breasts and her head tipped back of its own accord.

His mouth followed. He kissed the hollow of her throat, the place where he had undone her cloak, then lower, taking one nipple into the heat of his mouth. Pleasure pulled tight through her, bright and shocking. She made a sound into his hair. He sucked gently, then less gently, and her fingers dug into his shoulders. When he moved to the other breast she was already arching into him, shameless, her thighs restless under the blankets.

He eased her down. His hand slid over her stomach, over the curve of her hip, and then between her legs, and she was wet enough that there was no hiding it. His breath left him in a rough, quiet sound. Two fingers stroked through her, slow, learning her, and when he found the place that made her hips lift, he stayed there, circling, while she clutched at his wrist and tried to remember how to breathe.

"Jarrod."

"I have you."

He kissed her while he touched her, swallowing the noises she could not keep. The pleasure built in a tightening spiral, almost too much, and she broke against his hand with a startled cry, her body clenching, her face turned into his throat. He held her through it, murmuring something she did not catch, and did not take his hand away until she trembled down.

She reached for him then, impatient, and found him through his remaining clothes, thick and hot, the size of him enough to

make her pulse jump. He hissed when she closed her hand around him. She stroked, uncertain at first, then surer when his forehead dropped to her shoulder and his control frayed in her grip. He let her have that for a few heartbeats only. Then he caught her wrist, kissed her palm, and stripped the last of the linen away.

He settled between her thighs. The weight of him was a shock and a relief at once. He looked at her in the low lantern light, waiting, and she hooked a leg over his hip in answer.

"Yes," she said. "Now."

He pushed into her slowly. The stretch stole her breath. Full, so full, a sweet ache that edged toward pain and then, as he held still, toward something else. She felt every inch of him, the heat, the thickness, the way her body had to learn him. His arms shook with the effort of not driving home. She could hear the growl he would not let out, trapped in his chest against her breasts.

"Noelle."

"Don't you dare stop."

He laughed once, wrecked, and sank the rest of the way. She gasped. He kissed the sound from her mouth and began to move, long strokes that dragged over that same bright place inside her until she was lifting to meet him, her hands in his hair, her voice gone low and honest. She told him harder. She told him there. He gave her both, his control breaking in pieces, his mouth at her throat, his teeth grazing the join of her neck and shoulder as if he wanted to bite and would not quite.

The bed whispered. The storm went on. She wrapped both legs around him and held on as the pleasure gathered again, deeper this time, pulled from someplace she had not known she had. When it took her, she came with his name in her mouth, tightening around him in helpless pulses. He followed with a groan that sounded torn out of him, driving deep, his whole body going rigid in her arms as he spilled into her.

For a time there was only breathing. He stayed close above her, as if leaving would cost him. She stroked his back, damp now, and felt him shudder once more before he eased out and gathered her against his side.

He reached toward the lantern. She caught his wrist.

"A little light," she said. "Please."

He left it burning low. She looked at him, at the man the court never saw, and drew him back for a kiss that had no urgency left in it, only the want to keep touching.

Later, the fire settled and the room grew quiet. Noelle lay with her cheek against his shoulder while he traced idle circles over the hand resting on his chest. She realized she was holding herself still, afraid to disturb him.

"What is it?" he asked.

She hesitated. "Nothing. I was wondering whether I ought to move."

"Why?"

"You might want to sleep."

He drew her more securely against him. "Here is where I want you."

Her fingers curled around his. After a moment she released a long breath and felt the last of her vigilance ease. He kissed her hair. She stayed awake just long enough to feel his mouth there, and the storm passing over the roof, and the simple, astonishing fact of his arm around her, keeping her where she was.

Chapter Seven

On Christmas morning, Noelle woke against Jarrod's chest, his arm around her waist. Remembering the night made her want to hide her face and kiss him again in equal measure. When she shifted, his hand moved over her back.

"Good morning." He lay watching her, hair untidy against the pillow. Without the waiting court, he looked like a man who belonged in this bed with her. She wanted the sight every morning, and it frightened her.

"We have to go back," she said.

He brushed a curl away from her cheek. "Yes. After breakfast."

"Jarrod."

"I haven't changed my mind." His hand settled at the back of her neck. "Let me deal with the Council."

Once they were up, Jarrod brought her hairpins from the bedside shelf and placed them in a neat row on the table. Noelle looked from them to him and smiled. He had picked up the empty wood basket to refill it, but set it down when she passed. He caught her by the hand and drew her close enough to kiss.

"Breakfast," she reminded him afterward, though she had made no attempt to leave his arms.

"You are unusually concerned with breakfast."

"One of us must think beyond the next kiss."

"I have thought as far as the one after that."

She laughed and pushed gently at his chest. He let her go, but watched her cross to the pantry with the blanket still around her shoulders. Morning had brought none of the distance she feared. She could see that in his face every time she turned.

They ate at the same little table while the windows slowly brightened. Noelle spread the last of the preserves on his bread, and he gave her the larger portion without comment. It was easy to imagine another morning, another winter. She let herself do it while he checked that her boots had dried.

Before they left, she folded the blanket and laid it on the bed. Jarrod waited at the door with her cloak.

"I shall want to come back," she said.

"So shall I."

She looked at the bare mantel. "It needs a few things."

"Make a list." He fastened the cloak beneath her chin. "This time, we can bring them together."

* * *

"You sent a woman into a storm." Jarrod spoke with quiet anger. Noelle sat beside him at the head of the council table. After riding back through the easing storm, she had changed into a clean wool dress for the hearing. Across the high-windowed chamber, Myla faced them with the elders seated along the table. Rourke had just read Noelle's note and Amelia Dale's statement. Mother Agatha had returned from the shelters at dawn and now sat near the fire.

Myla lifted her chin. "I was protecting the future of this pack."

"You knew Amelia and her son were safe," Noelle said. "You found them the warm room. I thanked you for it."

Myla looked at her, and for the first time her polished certainty faltered. "You thanked me as though you belonged here already."

"She thanked you because you had helped someone," Jarrod said. "You used that trust to send her out alone."

“I have visited this house for years. Helped you host banquets. My father was given every reason to expect—”

“Your father was never given my promise.” Jarrod's voice stopped her. “If you believed otherwise, you could have asked me. You chose to punish her.”

Myla looked down at her hands. Noelle remembered the ledger, the blankets ready before anyone needed them. The woman who had done that work was also the woman who had stood in her doorway and lied about a sick child. Noelle could feel sorrow for the waste without wishing Jarrod to soften the consequences.

“You will return to your father as soon as the road is safe,” Jarrod said. “Under escort, with a full account of what you did. There will be no further discussion of marriage between our houses.” Myla's gaze flicked toward the elders, then dropped. This time she offered no defense. Jarrod turned to Rourke. “Have her belongings packed. She will remain in her rooms until she leaves.” At his nod, Rourke called a guard from the doorway to escort her out.

When the door closed behind her, Jarrod rose to face the elders. “Noelle is my chosen mate.”

Venn leaned forward from his place opposite them. “Majesty, a human cannot meet the requirements for a suitable Luna. Whatever you feel, the law remains.”

“Then we will find a way forward. But understand me now. I will not abandon her to preserve your approval.” Before the gathered council, Jarrod raised Noelle's hand to his mouth.

Noelle rose beside him. “And I choose you.”

Agatha, the ancient healer, rose from her chair by the fire and crossed to Noelle to study her pendant. “May I see your stone, child?”

Noelle lifted the pendant and turned it over. Warmth spread through her fingers as Jarrod stepped closer. Agatha studied the tiny crescent carved into its back. “Elspeth's. I knew her when we were girls. Moon-Touched blood can sleep through generations.

Sometimes it wakes for a mate." She looked up into Noelle's face and smiled. "There you are."

Jarrod touched Noelle's cheek. His eyes had gone gold. "Your eyes," he said softly. "They're silver."

"They've always been green." She let the pendant settle against her dress, caught his wrist, then looked at Agatha.

"Your blood is waking, child. The stone only answers it." Agatha turned to Venn. "She has wolf blood. The law is satisfied."

Venn studied Noelle's face, then gave a reluctant nod. Jarrod was still watching her, his thumb against her cheek. She took his face between her palms and kissed him again, while Rourke began finding urgent occupations for everyone else in the chamber.

* * *

That Christmas evening, Noelle entered the candlelit great hall with Jarrod. The pack and sheltered families filled the tables. The red Yule moon was visible through the open doors. Agatha had spent the afternoon with them discussing the evening's plans. The prayer and first offering would remain unchanged. Then would come their bond vows, the children's songs, gifts, and the feast.

Noelle waited beside Jarrod at the hearth while Agatha carried the silver bowl between the tables, receiving the first portion of the grain. No one touched the roast meat, glazed roots, or spiced loaves beneath their cloths.

Agatha thanked the Moon Goddess for the harvest and the lives sheltered through winter. Noelle bowed with the pack, then placed the first slice of her Christmas bread beside the grain. Jarrod's hand rested at her back as she spoke the words Agatha had taught her. Her Christmas and their Yule had been woven into one celebration, the pack's answering voices welcoming her into it.

Then, before his people, Jarrod offered Noelle his wolf, his blood, and his bond. She answered without hesitation. She bared

her neck to him, felt the brief sting of his bite, then his mouth gentle against the mark. He held her close while the pack welcomed its Luna, and she held him just as tightly.

After the offering was carried outside, the doors were drawn closed against the cold. The children began her winter song, their parents joining the second verse less confidently. Gifts appeared from beneath benches, wooden animals and ribbons, with schoolroom books finished by the scribes. A little girl recognized her own star on a cover. Noelle pressed her lips together before she could cry.

“Look at this, Miss Winters!” The boy who had hidden beneath the table ran to show her his wooden wolf.

“Luna,” Jarrod corrected gently. The child looked up at him, then back at Noelle.

“Look, Luna!” He presented the wolf again.

“And still Miss Winters in the schoolroom,” she told him. She admired every carved tooth, then laughed when he demonstrated its alarming growl. She sat beside Jarrod at the hearth-end table, leaning into his arm while platters passed and newly unwrapped toys joined the feast.

Beside his plate lay a small orange, slipped there while he had been watching the children. Jarrod looked at it, then at Noelle. She had peeled one narrow strip and curled it into a ribbon, leaving the rest whole.

“You needn't eat it,” she said quietly. “I remembered.”

He covered her hand beneath the table. Across the hall, a child laughed with a mouth full of Christmas bread. He looked toward the sound, his expression softening. Noelle squeezed his hand beneath the table and stayed beside him while he turned the orange gently in his free hand.

He lifted Noelle's hand and kissed it. She smiled at him, understanding enough to let the moment stand without asking him to explain.

Venn accepted spiced bread from a tray at their table. “The authorities you cited establish a precedent,” he conceded. “Other packs combine gifts and feasting with their observances. Mother Agatha is satisfied that the rite has been honored.” He eyed the ribbon above the hearth. “Though I doubt we needed quite so much of that.” Noelle hid a smile.

She started to rise as a ribbon came loose above the hearth. Jarrod caught her hand beneath the table.

“It can wait.” He leaned close. “There's something I'd like to show you.”

Jarrod fetched their cloaks from the pegs beside the door, helped her into hers and led her through a side door into the sheltered courtyard. Moonlight shone between its walls. He stopped beneath the arch beside the steps. “You wanted to see my wolf.”

“I did.” Her fingers tightened around his. “Would he mind?”

Jarrod kissed her palm. “You're our mate. He's been waiting rather impatiently.”

He went beneath the archway and laid aside his clothes in the shadows. Noelle watched him lower a hand to the snow. Dark fur spread where moonlight had touched his skin, his shoulders changing as he bent. Then a great wolf stood beneath the arch, gold eyes fixed on her face.

He came to her slowly. Noelle put out her hand, and he pressed his muzzle into it, warm breath curling around her fingers. She had known he would be large. She had not imagined the weight of his head when he lowered it for her touch, or the care with which he leaned against her. She buried both hands in the thick fur at his neck and bent to kiss him between the ears.

“You're beautiful,” she whispered. His eyes half closed beneath her hands. From inside came the pack's voices joining another of her songs, and Noelle stood with her cheek against his fur until the cold finally found her feet.

At last he stepped back beneath the arch and shifted into his human form. Noelle waited by the wall while he dressed. He returned to draw her chilled hands inside his coat. “We should go back.”

“In a moment.” She rose on her toes, smoothing the dark hair she had touched beside the fire. “I believe I was promised another kiss.”

“I don't recall limiting the number.” He guided her back to the doorway and bent his head. Noelle smiled against his mouth while warmth and music spilled out to greet them.

“Merry Christmas, Jarrod,” she whispered.

He held her close. “Happy Yuletide, my Luna.”

Thank You for Reading

Thank you for spending Christmas with Noelle and Jarrod.

This book began as a shorter story, narrated and illustrated on my YouTube channel, Midnight Crown Stories. If you'd like to hear where it started, watch *The Alpha King Brought a Human Home for Christmas* free on YouTube:

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With love,

ALORA C. KANE

Midnight Crown Stories



“Shut that, please.
I’ve only just got the room warm.”



“I have men who can do that.”
“Yes, but you’re here.”



A Christmas Morning
There were still ribbons to tie.

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who keeps finding reasons to linger.

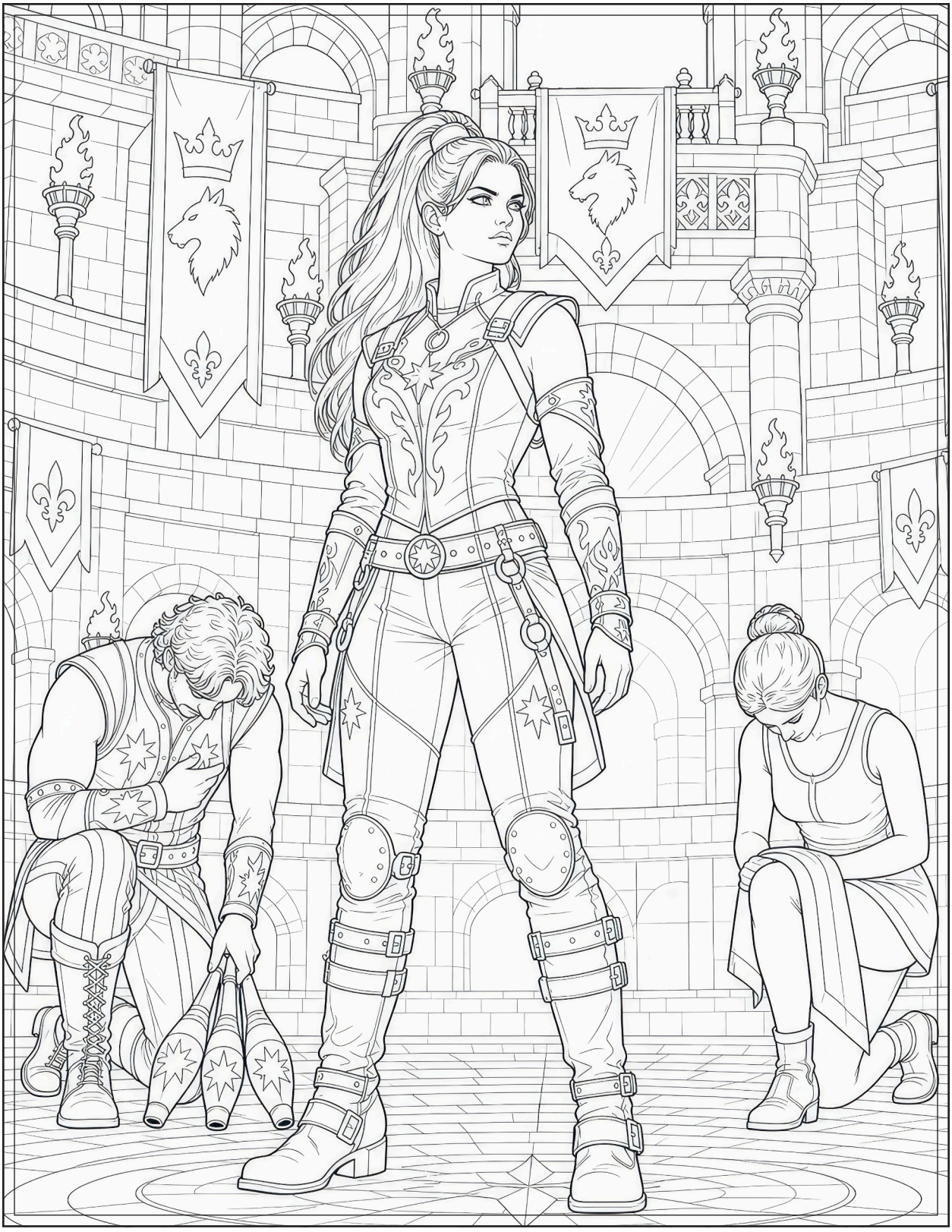
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She did not flinch. She did not bow.
She simply looked away.
No one in his courtyard looked at him like that.



Liam filled the narrow passage. “You shouldn’t be here.”
Nova held his gaze. “Neither should you.”
“My castle.”

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